



PAKISTAN HAS REFUSED TO ACCEPT VYAS (RIGHT) AS THE INDIAN HIGH COMMISSIONER

DELHI |

Diplomatic Muddle

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days was the tenure during which Vyas was the acting high commissioner in Pakistan before being expelled on February 8, 2003.

Has Delhi gone soft on Pakistan again? Last week when Pakistan refused to accept India's nominee for the new Indian high commissioner, it strained relations further between the two countries. The present Indian high commissioner Satyabrata Pal's term ends on February 28. According to usual practice, India had sounded Islamabad through diplomatic channels that it will be seeking an 'agreema', a diplomatic request for the appointment of a new envoy. Sudhir Vyas, currently India's ambassador to Bhutan, was named to succeed Pal. But Islamabad communicated its disapproval of Vyas since he was declared persona non grata and expelled from Pakistan in 2003 following the December 2001 attack on Parliament. In February 2003, India had expelled then acting Pakistani high commissioner Jalil Abbas Jilani, declared him persona non grata and registered a case against him for funding Kashmiri separatists. In a tit-for-tat, Pakistan expelled Vyas, the Acting Indian high commissioner. Following Pakistan's refusal, Delhi has withdrawn Vyas and has named Sharat Sabharwal as the new envoy. Vyas may now be sent to Germany as the ambassador. The standoff indicates the degree of mistrust between the two countries, and Pakistan's cussed approach has only widened the divide.

by Saurabh Shukla